

Task Blaster User Manual

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A native macOS GTD (Getting Things Done) productivity app with AI assistance, focus timers, and an MCP server for external integrations.

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1. Getting Started

Requirements

- macOS 26.4 or later
- An AI provider API key (optional, for AI features)

First Launch

When you first open Task Blaster, you'll see an empty Inbox. The app is organized as a split view:

- **Sidebar** (left) — navigation across GTD categories, tools, and organization views
- **Detail panel** (center) — the content for the selected sidebar item
- **Assistant panel** (right, hidden by default) — an AI chat inspector toggled with `⌘J`

Start by capturing tasks into the Inbox using the Quick Add bar (`⌘N`) or Brain Dump (`⌘⇧B`).

Quick Tour

1. **Capture** — throw everything into the Inbox. Don't organize yet.
2. **Clarify** — process inbox items one by one (`⌘⇧P`), deciding what each item is and where it belongs.
3. **Organize** — assign projects, contexts, due dates, and defer dates.
4. **Review** — run the guided Weekly Review (`⌘⇧W`) to keep your system current.
5. **Do** — work from your Next Actions list, using Pomo or Overdrive for timed focus.

2. The GTD Workflow

Task Blaster implements the full GTD methodology:

Category	What belongs here
Inbox	Anything captured — unsorted, unclarified
Next Actions	Concrete, actionable tasks you can do right now
Waiting For	Items delegated to someone else, with optional follow-up dates
Someday/Maybe	Things you might do but aren't committed to yet
Reference	Non-actionable information you want to keep
Done	Completed tasks (archive)
Trash	Discarded items (can be restored or permanently deleted)

Tasks move through these categories as you clarify and work on them. Every action in the app is undoable (⌘Z).

3. Screens & Panels

Inbox

Your universal capture bucket. New tasks land here by default. Use the Quick Add bar at the top to add items rapidly. Process them with the AI-assisted Process Inbox sheet (⌘⇧P), which walks through each item and suggests a category, project, and context.

Today

Shows tasks that are overdue or due today, grouped into sections. This is your daily action list — what needs attention right now.

Next Actions

Your working list of concrete next steps. Supports drag-and-drop reordering for manual priority sorting. Deferred tasks (with a future defer date) are hidden until their defer date arrives.

Waiting For

Delegated items. Each can have a follow-up date, and overdue follow-ups are highlighted in red. Use the context menu to set follow-up dates and update status.

Someday/Maybe

A parking lot for ideas and possibilities. Review this list during your Weekly Review to see if anything is ready to activate.

Reference

Non-actionable information you want to keep. Read-only from a GTD perspective — items here are archived but searchable.

Done

Completed task archive. Tasks move here when you check them off. View your completion history and patterns.

Trash

Soft-deleted items. You can restore tasks from here or permanently delete them with “Empty Trash” from the GTD menu.

Projects

Lists all projects grouped by status (Active, Someday, Completed, Dropped). Click a project to see its tasks. A warning badge appears on projects that have no next action defined.

Areas

Areas of responsibility (e.g., “Health”, “Career”, “Home”). Projects can be grouped under areas. Use areas to ensure you’re covering all parts of your life during reviews.

Contexts

Context tags (e.g., “@Computer”, “@Phone”, “@Errands”) that describe where or with what tool a task can be done. Assign contexts to tasks so you can filter by what’s available to you right now.

Search

Full-text search across task titles and notes. Triggered by the native search bar (**⌘F**) or by navigating to the Search sidebar item.

Pomo

The Pomodoro timer panel. Start work sessions linked to specific tasks, track streaks, and view analytics.

Overdrive

Focus Overdrive sessions — structured, multi-phase timed routines for deep work (e.g., Video Study, Coding Sprint, Deep Writing).

4. Key Workflows

Quick Add (**⌘N**)

Opens the Quick Add bar at the top of the current panel. Type a task title and press Return to add it to the Inbox. Press Tab to expand into the full task editor.

Brain Dump (**⌘⇧B**)

A rapid-capture sheet for getting everything out of your head. Two modes:

- **Quick Capture** — type one task per line, rapid-fire entry
- **Guided Capture** — AI-coached prompts across life areas with follow-up questions, draft review, and batch save

Process Inbox (⌘⇧P)

Walks through inbox items one at a time. For each item, you can:

- Set a category (Next Action, Waiting For, Someday, Reference, Trash)
- Assign a project and context
- Use AI Clarify to get automated suggestions

Weekly Review (⌘⇧W)

A guided 6-step review process:

1. **Process Inbox** — clear every item
2. **Review Next Actions** — scan for relevance, complete or defer
3. **Review Waiting For** — follow up on delegated items
4. **Review Someday/Maybe** — activate, remove, or keep
5. **Review Areas** — check your areas of responsibility are up to date
6. **Review Projects** — ensure every active project has a next action

Each step navigates you to the relevant panel. AI suggestions are available at several steps (batch clarify, suggest contexts/durations, find stalled projects). Jump to any step with ⌘⇧1 through ⌘⇧6 .

On completion, you see a summary with duration, tasks completed, and AI suggestions accepted. A review record is saved for tracking review frequency.

What's Next? (⌘⇧N)

AI-assisted task recommendation. Analyzes your current Next Actions and recommends what to work on next based on due dates, contexts, and project priorities.

AI Cleanup (⌘⇧K)

A system health wizard that detects and fixes:

- Orphaned tasks (no project, stale waiting-for items)
- Duplicate or unused contexts
- Stale or empty projects
- Overdue tasks needing attention

Bulk Edit (⌘E)

Select multiple tasks (Cmd+Click or Shift+Click), then bulk edit to change category, project, context, or due date across all selected items at once.

Task Completion Chaining

When you complete a task, the app suggests the next task to work on — either the next task in the same project or your top next action. A toast notification shows the completed task with an Undo button.

5. Task Properties

Each task can have:

Property	Description
Title	The task name. Double-click to edit inline.
Notes	Longer description or reference material
Category	GTD bucket (Inbox, Next Action, Waiting For, etc.)
Project	Optional project assignment
Context	Optional context tag (e.g., @Computer)
Due Date	When the task is due. Double-click the date label to edit inline with natural language (e.g., “tomorrow”, “3d”, “next friday”).
Defer Date	Task is hidden from active lists until this date
Duration	Estimated time (displayed as minutes, hours, or days)
Recurrence	Daily, Weekly, Monthly, or Yearly. Completing a recurring task auto-creates the next occurrence.
Subtasks	Nested child tasks. Deleting a parent deletes all subtasks.
Follow-up Date	For Waiting For items — when to check on the delegate

Natural Language Dates

All date fields accept natural language input:

- today , tomorrow , yesterday
- 3d , 2w , 1m (relative offsets)
- monday , next friday , weekday names
- eow (end of week), eom (end of month)
- ISO format: 2026-04-15

Inline Editing

- **Double-click a task title** to rename it inline
 - **Double-click a due date label** to edit the due date with natural language
 - Press **Return** to confirm, **Escape** to cancel
-

6. Projects, Areas & Contexts

Projects

A project is any outcome that requires more than one action step. Projects have:

- **Title** and **Notes**
- **Status:** Active, Someday, Completed, or Dropped
- **Area:** Optional grouping under an Area of responsibility
- **Tasks:** The actions needed to complete the project

Create projects from the GTD menu or from the Projects panel. Drag tasks onto a project in the sidebar to assign them.

Areas

Areas of responsibility represent the roles and commitments in your life (e.g., “Health”, “Career”, “Family”). Unlike projects, areas are ongoing and don’t have a completion state.

Use areas to organize projects and ensure comprehensive coverage during reviews.

Contexts

Contexts are tags that describe the tool, location, or situation needed to work on a task.

Common contexts:

- `@Computer` — tasks requiring a computer
- `@Phone` — calls and mobile tasks
- `@Errands` — tasks to do while out
- `@Home` , `@Office` — location-based

Default contexts are seeded on first launch. Create custom ones from the GTD menu or context picker. Duplicate contexts (differing only by case or @ prefix) are automatically merged.

7. Pomodoro Timer

The Pomodoro technique structures work into focused intervals:

1. **Work** — 25 minutes of focused effort
2. **Short Break** — 5 minutes
3. Repeat 4 times, then take a **Long Break** — 15 minutes

Using the Timer

1. Navigate to the **Pomo** panel in the sidebar
2. Optionally select a task to link the session to
3. Click **Start Work** to begin
4. The timer counts down in the panel, menu bar, and dock progress ring
5. Notifications alert you when phases end

Controls

- **Pause / Resume** — pause the current phase
- **Cancel** — stop the session entirely
- **Skip Break** — jump straight to the next work session

Settings

Configure durations in Settings → Pomodoro:

- Work session length (default: 25 min)
- Short break length (default: 5 min)
- Long break length (default: 15 min)
- Work sessions before long break (default: 4)

Analytics

View session history and patterns in the Pomo Analytics sheet (View → Pomo Analytics). See total sessions, completed streaks, and average durations.

Context Menu Integration

Right-click any task and choose “Start Pomo” or “Start Overdrive Session” to jump directly into a timed session linked to that task.

8. Focus Overdrive

Focus Overdrive provides structured, multi-phase session routines for deep work. Unlike the simple Pomodoro cycle, each routine has custom phases with specific instructions, prep checklists, and optional wall cues.

Built-in Routines

- **Video Study** — watch/synthesize cycles with capture breaks
- **Audio Learning** — listen/capture cycles for audio content
- **Digital Reading** — read/summarize cycles for on-screen material
- **Paper Reading** — focused reading with pen-and-paper notes
- **Deep Writing Flow** — alternating draft and revision phases
- **Admin Sprint** — rapid task processing with progress checks
- **Presentation Build** — structured slide/notes/rehearsal cycles
- **Quick Start** — short warm-up routine to build momentum
- **Coding Plan Sprint** — plan/design phases before implementation
- **Coding Execution Sprint** — focused coding with test/review breaks
- **Debugging Reset** — structured debug/hypothesize/test cycles

Running a Session

1. Navigate to the **Overdrive** panel
2. Browse the routine gallery and select a routine
3. Review the prep checklist — check off items before starting

4. Optionally link a task and choose loop/cycle-cap mode
5. Click **Start Session**
6. The timer runs through each phase with on-screen instructions
7. At phase transitions, you can capture notes (if the phase requires them)
8. A summary shows when the session ends

Session Modes

- **Loop** — cycles repeat indefinitely until you stop
- **Cycle Cap** — stop after a set number of complete cycles

Wall Cues

Some routines include wall cues — floating cards that appear mid-session at a configured elapsed time (e.g., a 45-minute stretch reminder). They auto-dismiss after 15 seconds.

Custom Routines

Edit `routines.json` in the app bundle to add your own routines. Each routine needs:

- `id`, `name`, `goal`
- `prep_checklist` — array of setup steps
- `phases` — array with `id`, `label`, `duration_sec`, `instructions`, `next_prep`, `completes_cycle`, `requires_note`
- `wall_cue` (optional) — `trigger_elapsed_sec`, `title`, `instructions`, `trigger_once`

9. Focus Mode

Focus Mode (`⌘F`) is a distraction-free overlay that covers the entire window. It hides the sidebar and detail panel, showing only:

- The current task name (if a Pomo or Overdrive session is active)
- A large, centered timer display
- Pause/resume and cancel controls
- If no timer is running, a calm idle screen

Use Focus Mode when you want to eliminate visual distractions and concentrate solely on the current task and timer.

Toggle it from the View menu or with `⌘⇧F`. Exit via the overlay button or the same shortcut.

10. The AI Assistant

The AI Assistant (`⌘J`) is an inspector panel on the right side of the window. It provides a conversational interface for querying and managing your tasks.

How It Works

1. **Local queries first** — common questions (task counts, lists, recommendations) are answered instantly without calling an AI provider
2. **LLM fallback** — complex queries are forwarded to your configured AI provider
3. **Tool calling** — the assistant can read and modify your tasks using the same MCP tool surface that external clients use
4. **Draft-first mutations** — any change the AI proposes (create, complete, move) appears as a confirmation card. You approve or dismiss before anything happens.

What You Can Ask

- “How many tasks are in my inbox?”
- “What are my next actions?”
- “Pick a random task from the Movies project”
- “Create a task called ‘Buy groceries’ in next actions”
- “Mark ‘Submit report’ as done”
- “Move ‘Research flights’ to someday”

Local Query Examples (Instant, No AI Required)

- `inbox` / `next` / `waiting` / `someday` — list tasks by category
- `overdue` / `today` / `due this week` — date-based queries
- `longest task` / `shortest task` — find extremes
- `recommend` / `what should I work on` — smart next-task suggestion
- `help` — list available commands

Assistant Profile

Customize the assistant's identity in Settings → Assistant:

- **Name** — change from the default “Jarvis” to your preference
- **Portrait** — choose an icon
- **Traits** — comma-separated personality descriptors (e.g., “concise, proactive, professional”)

The name and traits are injected into the AI system prompt, shaping the assistant's conversational tone.

11. AI Features

AI features require a configured provider (Settings → AI). All features have non-AI fallbacks.

Feature	What it does
Inbox Clarify	Suggests category, project, and context for inbox items
Suggest Next Step	Proposes a concrete next action for a project
Suggest Context	Recommends a context tag based on task content
Suggest Duration	Estimates time required for a task
Break Down Task	Decomposes a complex task into subtasks
What's Next?	Recommends the highest-priority next task
Brain Dump Coach	Guided capture with contextual follow-up questions
Bulk Create Tasks	Parses text/documents into a structured task list
AI Cleanup	Detects system-wide data issues and suggests fixes
Assistant	Multi-turn conversational chat with tool access

Supported Providers

- **Claude** (Anthropic) — direct API integration
- **OpenAI-compatible** — any endpoint following the OpenAI API shape (including self-hosted)
- **NanoGPT** — managed provider option
- **Local LLM** — LM Studio, llama.cpp, or any local server at `http://localhost:1234/v1`

Configuration

In Settings → AI:

- Select a default provider and model
- Enter API keys (stored in UserDefaults)
- Enable/disable individual AI features
- Set per-feature model overrides
- Customize prompt templates
- Adjust the duration buffer (% added to AI-suggested durations)
- Test provider connectivity

12. Data Management

Backup & Restore

- **Create Backup** (File → Create Backup) — saves a timestamped `.zip` of your SwiftData store
- **Restore Backup** (File → Restore Backup) — replaces the current store with a backup. A safety backup is automatically created before restoring.

CSV Import & Export

- **Export** (File → Export Tasks CSV) — exports all tasks with title, category, project, context, dates, duration, recurrence, and notes
- **Import** (File → Import CSV) — imports tasks from a CSV file, auto-creating missing projects and contexts

Import from Text

The Document Import sheet (`⌘D`) lets you paste or type freeform text, and AI parses it into a structured task list for review before saving.

Python GTD Import

If you're migrating from the Python GTD app, use File → Import from Python GTD to import a `.gtddbbackup` file. The importer handles schema differences and creates all tasks, projects, areas, and contexts.

Undo & Redo

Every task operation supports undo (`⌘Z`) and redo (`⌘⇧Z`). A toast notification appears after each action showing what happened and offering an Undo button.

13. MCP Server

Task Blaster includes an in-process HTTP MCP (Model Context Protocol) server that lets external AI clients (like Claude Desktop, Claude Code, or custom tools) query and modify your tasks.

Setup

1. Open Settings (or the MCP Server sheet from Help → MCP Server)
2. Enable the MCP server
3. Set a port (default: auto)
4. Set a bearer token for authentication
5. Toggle whether mutations (create, update, delete) are allowed

Available Tools (21)

Tasks: `task_list` , `task_get` , `task_create` , `task_update` , `task_complete` , `task_trash` , `task_move`

Projects: `project_list` , `project_get` , `project_create`

Taxonomy: `context_list`, `area_list`

Convenience: `inbox`, `today`, `next_actions`, `waiting_for`

Health: `ping`

MCPB Bundle Export

The MCP Info sheet offers a one-click MCPB bundle export for easy installation into MCP-compatible hosts.

Security

- Bearer token authentication required on all requests
- Mutation toggle allows read-only mode
- Tool call logging available for diagnostics

14. Settings & Configuration

Open Settings with `⌘,`. Available tabs:

Appearance

- **Mode** — Light, Dark, or System
- **Theme** — choose from multiple color themes with live preview swatches

General

- **Task Breakdown Mode** — when AI breaks down a task, create subtasks (default) or independent tasks
- **Show Menu Bar Icon** — toggle the menu bar extra
- **Import from Python GTD** — one-time migration from the Python app

Pomodoro

- Work, short break, and long break durations
- Number of work sessions before a long break

AI

- Provider selection and API keys
- Per-feature enable/disable toggles
- Model overrides per feature
- Custom prompt templates
- Duration buffer percentage
- Provider connection testing

Assistant

- Assistant name (default: “Jarvis”)
- Portrait icon
- Personality traits (injected into AI prompts)

Logging

- Debug logging toggle
 - Detailed logging toggle (warning: may capture user data)
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15. Keyboard Shortcuts

Tasks

Shortcut	Action
⌘N	Quick Add / New Task
⌘⇧B	Brain Dump
⌘⇧N	What's Next?
⌘⇧W	Weekly Review
⌘⇧P	Process Inbox
⌘⇧D	Import Tasks from Text
⌘⇧K	AI Cleanup

Navigation

Shortcut	Action
⌘J	Toggle Assistant
⌘F	Search
⌘⇧F	Focus Mode
⌘,	Settings
⌘⇧M	Task Metrics

Editing

Shortcut	Action
<code>⌘Z</code>	Undo
<code>⌘⇧Z</code>	Redo
<code>⌘E</code>	Bulk Edit
<code>Space</code>	Complete selected task(s)
<code>Delete</code>	Trash selected task(s)
<code>Esc</code>	Clear selection
Double-click	Inline edit title or due date

Weekly Review

Shortcut	Action
<code>⇧1</code>	Step 1: Process Inbox
<code>⇧2</code>	Step 2: Next Actions
<code>⇧3</code>	Step 3: Waiting For
<code>⇧4</code>	Step 4: Someday/Maybe
<code>⇧5</code>	Step 5: Areas
<code>⇧6</code>	Step 6: Projects

System

Shortcut	Action
<code>^⌘Space</code>	Global Capture (system-wide)
<code>⌘/</code>	Keyboard Shortcuts reference

16. macOS Integration

Task Blaster is a fully native macOS app with deep system integration:

- **Menu Bar Icon** — shows live Pomo/Focus timer countdown with phase-appropriate icon
 - **Dock Badge** — displays counts for inbox or today's tasks
 - **Dock Progress Ring** — circular progress indicator during Pomo/Focus sessions
 - **Global Hotkey** (`^⌘Space`) — capture tasks from any app without switching windows
 - **System Notifications** — alerts for Pomo phase changes, overdue tasks, and Focus session transitions
 - **Haptic Feedback** — trackpad haptics on task mutations and undo
 - **System Sounds** — completion tink on task done, glass on review complete
 - **Native File Dialogs** — backup, restore, import, and export use standard macOS panels
 - **Undo/Redo** — integrated with the system undo manager, accessible from Edit menu
 - **Appearance** — respects system light/dark mode with custom theme overrides
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17. Troubleshooting

The app won't build / tests fail

Run `make doctor` to check your environment. Ensure:

- macOS 26.4+ and the latest Xcode with Swift 6 toolchain
- `mad-toolkit` is checked out at `../swift-libs/mad-toolkit`
- Run `make bootstrap` to install tool dependencies

AI features aren't working

- Check Settings → AI: is a provider configured with a valid API key?
- Use the “Test Connection” button to verify connectivity
- Check Console.app logs (Help → Open Logs) for AI error details
- Enable debug logging in Settings → Logging for more diagnostics

Tasks aren't appearing

- Check the sidebar category — tasks may be in a different bucket
- Check for active defer dates — deferred tasks are hidden until their defer date
- Use Search (`⌘F`) to find tasks across all categories

MCP server not responding

- Verify the server is enabled in Settings or Help → MCP Server
- Check the port isn't in use by another process
- Ensure the bearer token matches what your client is sending
- Check Console.app for MCP server logs

Duplicate contexts appearing

Duplicate contexts (differing by case or `@` prefix) are automatically merged on launch. If you still see duplicates, they may have different Unicode normalization — report via Help → Report Issue.

Data migration errors

The app runs `DataIntegrityService.healDuplicateIdentifiers()` on every launch to repair stores from older builds. If you encounter persistent errors, create a backup first, then try relaunching.

18. Glossary

Term	Definition
GTD	Getting Things Done — David Allen’s productivity methodology
Inbox	The universal capture bucket for unprocessed items
Next Action	A concrete, physical action you can take right now
Waiting For	An item delegated to someone else
Someday/Maybe	A possibility you’re not committed to yet
Project	Any desired outcome requiring more than one action step
Area	An ongoing area of responsibility in your life
Context	A tag describing where/how a task can be done
Weekly Review	A regular check-in to keep your GTD system current
Pomodoro	A time-boxing technique using 25-minute work intervals
Focus Overdrive	Structured multi-phase focus sessions with custom routines
Focus Mode	A distraction-free overlay hiding everything except the timer
MCP	Model Context Protocol — a standard for AI tool integration
Brain Dump	A rapid-capture session to empty your head into the Inbox
Defer Date	A date before which a task is hidden from active lists
Wall Cue	A mid-session floating reminder in Focus Overdrive

Task Blaster is built with Swift 6, SwiftUI, and SwiftData. Licensed under MIT.